



MODULE 2

## Coaching Style & Autonomy

*Do you motivate players — or do you teach them to motivate themselves?*

### CORE THEORY

Self-Determination Theory (Deci & Ryan, 1985) shows that people are most motivated when three basic needs are met: autonomy (I have choice), competence (I can do it), and relatedness (I belong). Controlling coaches who rely solely on pressure and enforcement undermine intrinsic motivation. Autonomy-supportive coaching demonstrably leads to better performance, less burnout, and higher long-term enjoyment of sport.

Source: Deci & Ryan (1985, 2000) · Mageau & Vallerand (2003) · Amorose & Anderson-Butcher (2007)

*"The best coaches create conditions where players want to surpass themselves — not because they have to, but because they want to."*

— Daniel Pink

*"Control is the enemy of autonomy. And autonomy is the engine of growth."*

— Edward Deci

### SELF-REFLECTION

- 1 Do your players genuinely have input in training content, rules, or team agreements? Or is it fake autonomy?
- 2 When do you give instructions vs. when do you ask questions? What is the ratio?
- 3 Which player on your team needs the most structured environment — and which needs the most freedom? Do you treat them differently?
- 4 How do you react when a player wants to try something different than what you suggest? What does that say about your style?
- 5 What would change in your training if you let players design one session entirely themselves?

### NOTES

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**BOOKS**

- **Drive**  
Daniel Pink  
**Why:** The science of motivation in one accessible book. Intrinsic vs. extrinsic, and what coaches get wrong about rewards.
- **Mindset**  
Carol Dweck  
**Why:** Fixed vs. growth mindset. How you as a coach create — or destroy — a growth climate with your words and reactions.
- **Why Motivating People Doesn't Work and What Does**  
Susan Fowler  
**Why:** Practical book on optimal motivation. Translates SDT directly into coaching practice.

**VIDEO'S / TED TALKS**

- **The Puzzle of Motivation**  
Daniel Pink (TED Talk)  
[ted.com/talks/dan\\_pink\\_the\\_puzzle\\_of\\_motivation](https://ted.com/talks/dan_pink_the_puzzle_of_motivation)  
Watch: the Candle Problem experiment. External rewards kill creative thinking.
- **The Power of Believing You Can Improve**  
Carol Dweck (TED Talk)  
[ted.com/talks/carol\\_dweck\\_the\\_power\\_of\\_believing\\_that\\_you\\_can\\_improve](https://ted.com/talks/carol_dweck_the_power_of_believing_that_you_can_improve)  
How "not yet" is more powerful than "no." Applicable in every coaching interaction.

**PODCASTS**

- **The Science of Sport**  
Episode on intrinsic motivation in youth sport  
[scienceofsport.com](https://scienceofsport.com)
- **Kwame Christian — Negotiate Anything**  
How to move people without forcing them  
[negotiateanything.com](https://negotiateanything.com)

**⚡ ACTION THIS WEEK**

Observe yourself for one week: note each time you give an instruction vs. ask a question. What is the ratio? What do you want to change?

One way I will give more autonomy to my players:

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